The map of disruption tells the story. In Punjab, with early April rainfall nearly 470 per cent above normal, over 125,000 acres are suspected to be impacted. Haryana was badly hit too. In parts of Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, hailstorms worsened it, affecting wheat and mustard. In Uttar Pradesh, the damage is diffused but no less consequential, particularly for small farmers dependent on local markets.

THE WORST TIMING

Wheat, in its final grain-filling and maturation stage, needs dry weather: ideally, 28-32 degree Celsius and low humidity. That hardens the grain, its moisture falling to a good sub-12 per cent. But the northern plains saw days dip to 22-26 degree Celsius, with high humidity, rainfall, even hail.

Rain at this stage alters the grain. Moisture seeps into the kernels, causing shrivelling, discoloration, even fungal infection. The result is a crop that may still be harvested, but can be sold only at a steep discount. Affected farmers are reporting price cuts of Rs 300-500 per quintal, though the Minimum Support Price stands at Rs 2,585.

MACRO PAIN

India is still expected to produce close to 122 million tonnes of wheat this season, 2 per cent higher than last year. There is no immediate threat to overall availability. Yet a significant share of this output may not meet procurement or processing standards. What's unfolding is a compression in usable supply.

This is aggravated in *mandis* across Punjab and Haryana, where harvested wheat has been lying in the open, exposed to rain due to delays in procurement and a shortage in covered storage. Crops that survived the weather in the field are at risk of being downgraded after harvest. The losses are compounding.

Wheat's central place in India's consumption basket also gives it inflationary weight. If not managed in time, economists estimate a 20-40 basis point effect on food inflation, with a spillover on poultry and dairy via rising feed costs. Inflation had otherwise been showing signs of moderation, and the Reserve Bank of India was seen to be leaning towards policy easing. Layered on top of global uncertainties, this complicates that further.

The impact on rural incomes is more worrying. Farmers face income losses of 10–30 per cent, enough to wipe out an entire season's margin. For small and marginal farmers, who account for over 85 per cent of landholdings, that's more than a setback.

Close to 45 per cent of India's workforce is still tied to farming, so expect a hit to rural consumption—a key driver of demand across sectors, from fast-moving consumer goods to two-wheelers and entry-level appliances.

The Punjab and Haryana CMs, Bhagwant Mann and Nayab Singh Saini, seek eased quality norms, fast procurement and compensation for farmers. The Centre has signalled openness to the first two requests. ■

Takeaways

- **Unseasonal rain on the eve of wheat harvest hits rabi volumes, quality**
- **Affected: 250,000 hectares, in five states; half of it in Punjab**
- **20-40 basis point rise in food inflation, fall in rural demand likely**

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

Akhilesh's Wagon Goes West

Holding up a wide caste umbrella at Dadri rally, the SP boss inaugurates his 2027 campaign from western UP

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

AS THE WAR GEOGRAPHY FOR 2027 GETS drawn, the Samajwadi Party (SP) has made an early strategic choice. By opting for a rally in Dadri to launch his campaign, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has signalled that western Uttar Pradesh is where the contest will get decided. With 140-odd seats spread across 32 districts—nearly 35 per cent of the 403-seat assembly—this arc has long been UP's political hinge. More than bulk, what makes for a dynamic essential to control is its dense mix of castes and communities, with complex interrelations. This is where the SP is crafting a sharpened plan.

A POLITICAL COMPLEX

With Jats, Gujjars, Muslims and a rainbow of backward classes, group dynamics here are inflected both by identity-based and economic power relations. Farmer politics runs deep through its sugarcane belt. A strong middle-class Hindu vote in Noida and Ghaziabad leans saffronward. The older towns in their shadow also host an evolving Muslim lower middle class, some moving up from farm labour status. A strong Ambedkarite mobilisation of Dalits also colours the region deeply.

This entire social complex also has a history of trauma by now, fault lines that continue to influence political alignments. It's this mixed soil that the SP is trying to till, with a persuasive, comprehensive argument against BJP rule. It inaugurates